Metaphors across Languages

Francis Bond

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Overview

1. Prototypes and Categories
2. Metaphor
3. Spatial and Orientational Metaphors
4. Structural and Ontological Metaphors
5. Metonymy
6. Case Study: Anger
7. Metaphor across Asian Languages
8. Conclusions

Two Ways to Organize Concepts

prototypes	categories have a centre and edges
metaphor and **metonymy**	extend categories to new domains

This week's question: how much of this is **shared** across East and Southeast Asia, and how much is **language particular**?

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Prototypes

- Categories are organized around a **prototype**
- What is a typical BIRD? A typical piece of FURNITURE?

a typical BIRD	has feathers, warbles, flies, lays eggs
a penguin	has feathers, lays eggs ...

Pioneered by Rosch (1973) and Rosch et al. (1976) (very readable)

Relations between Concepts

- The commonest link is **hypernymy**: a DOG is an ANIMAL
- Subordinate concepts **inherit** from superordinate ones
- Larger units of knowledge are **frames**

Built as resources: WordNet (Fellbaum, 1998), FrameNet (Johnson et al., 2002)

The Basic Level

superordinate	basic	subordinate
vehicle	***bus***	***school bus***
jewelry	***necklace***	***bib necklace***
animal	***dog***	***poodle***

Basic-level names are recognized fastest, used most, learned first, short, and common in compounds

The Most Informative Level

- Members share **many** attributes with each other
- ...and **few** with other categories

Where the level sits varies: ***dog*** is basic at the species level, ***bird*** and ***fish*** higher, and it differs between groups of people. Frequency is tied to the basic level, but not the same

Linguistic Relativity

- Does what is **easy to say** affect how we **think**?
- Colours are easier to tell apart if you have names for them
- English and Chinese speakers differ on substances vs individuals

key is described as ...	
German (masculine)	hard, heavy, jagged, metal, useful
Spanish (feminine)	golden, intricate, little, lovely, shiny, tiny

Most confirmed differences are very, very subtle

The Sapir–Whorf Hypothesis

strong	language *determines* thought
weak	language *influences* thought and behaviour

Sapir and Whorf never wrote together, and never stated a hypothesis, let alone two versions of one

What Whorf Actually Said

We dissect nature along lines laid down by our native language. The categories and types that we isolate from the world of phenomena we do not find there because they stare every observer in the face; on the contrary, the world is presented in a kaleidoscope flux of impressions which has to be organized by our minds—and this means largely by the linguistic systems of our minds. We cut nature up, organize it into concepts, and ascribe significances as we do, largely because we are parties to an agreement to organize it in this way—an agreement that holds throughout our speech community and is codified in the patterns of our language [...] all observers are not led by the same physical evidence to the same picture of the universe, unless their linguistic backgrounds are similar, or can in some way be calibrated.

Whorf (Carroll; Ed.); 1956: pp. 212–214

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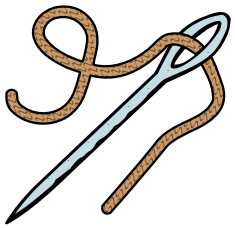
7 Metaphor across Asian Languages

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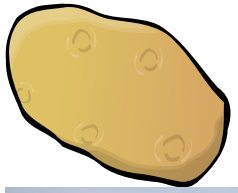
Metaphor Extends a Word by Similarity

eye "body part used for vision"

the eye of a needle



the eye of a potato



the eye of a storm



Shared: a roundish shape, more or less in the centre of something larger

Eyes in Other Languages

		literally	means
Mandarin	针眼 *zhēnyǎn*	needle-eye	needle's eye; stye
	针鼻儿 *zhēnbír*	needle-nose	needle's eye
Japanese	台風の目 *taifū no me*	typhoon's eye	eye of the typhoon
Malay	*mata air*	eye water	spring, source
	mata hari	eye day	sun
	mata pelajaran	eye lesson	school subject
	mata uang	eye money	currency

Some extensions travel, some do not. Which ones work in your language?

Dead Metaphors

booking a flight *tabling a motion*
seeing the point *stealing the headlines*
buying time

- Once accepted, the new sense feels **separate**: no special processing
- The main source of **polysemy**

Metaphor Is Everywhere

The price of sprouts went up.
She's coming out of a coma.
Felix is under age.
I killed his argument.
Their love is blossoming.
She has a fertile imagination.

Metaphors are non-prototypical uses of words. Counting frozen ones, we may use more metaphor than literal language

Metaphors We Live By

> *Our conceptual system is fundamentally metaphorical in nature*
>
> Lakoff and Johnson (1980)

conventional	well established, yet still metaphorical
systematic	part of larger domains
asymmetrical	the **abstract** in terms of the **concrete**

Cognitive semantics: no separation between cognition and linguistic knowledge

Good Metaphors: Not Too Close, Not Too Far

too similar	too different	just right
#*Wine is whisky*	#*His feet were stars*	*Life is a subway train*
#*Cars are trucks*	#*Her cheeks were typewriters*	*Men are thistles*
#*Jam is honey*	#*Her knees were penguins*	*He posted the toast down to his stomach*

Different fields, sharing one minor characteristic: the dissimilarity tells the listener to start matching

Source and Target Domains

Metaphors enable us to understand one domain of experience in terms of another. *Lakoff and Turner (1989)*



Written **TARGET** is **SOURCE**: LIFE is a JOURNEY. The mapping is **systematic**: a whole structure is carried over, not a single word

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Spatial Metaphors

- Give a concept an orientation: ***up–down***, ***in–out***, ***front–back***, ***deep–shallow***
- HAPPY is UP: *I'm feeling up today*
- Physical, but they can still **vary**

In most cultures the FUTURE is in FRONT; for the Aymara of the Andes (Bolivia, Peru, Chile) it is behind

HAPPY is UP; HEALTHY is UP

HAPPY is UP	HEALTHY is UP
I'm feeling up.	*He's at the peak of health.*
That boosted my spirits.	*Lazarus rose from the dead.*
You're in high spirits.	*He's in top shape.*
I'm feeling down.	*He fell ill.*
He is really low these days.	*He came down with the flu.*
My spirits sank.	*He dropped dead.*

CONTROL is UP; AWAKE is UP

CONTROL is UP	AWAKE is UP
I am on top of the situation.	*Get up.*
He's at the height of his power.	*He rises early.*
He's in the upper echelon.	*He fell asleep.*
He is under my control.	*He dropped off to sleep.*
He fell from power.	*He sank into a coma.*

VIRTUE is UP; MORE is UP

VIRTUE is UP	MORE is UP
He is high-minded.	*The number keeps going up.*
She is upright.	*His errors are incredibly low.*
He is underhanded.	*What is the upper bound?*
I wouldn't stoop to that.	
That is beneath me.	

Why UP?

pile things up	more reaches higher
healthy people	stand upright
when we are awake	we stand up

These metaphors recur across unrelated languages because they are grounded in the same bodies

CONTROL is UP in Chinese and Japanese

	Mandarin	Japanese	means
上级	*shàngjí*		superior
下级	*xiàjí*		subordinate
上司	*shàngsi*	*jōshi*	boss
部下		*buka*	subordinate (“under the section”)
目上		*meue*	one’s senior (“above the eye”)

Shared Sino-vocabulary carries shared metaphors. Borrowing, or would the metaphor be there anyway?

Mandarin Time Runs Down, the Past Lies Ahead

上个月	*shàng ge yuè*	last month (“up month”)
下个月	*xià ge yuè*	next month (“down month”)
上午	*shàngwǔ*	morning
下午	*xiàwǔ*	afternoon
以前	*yǐqián*	before (“taking the front”)
以后	*yǐhòu*	after (“taking the back”)

English time is horizontal: *the week ahead*, *back in 1999*. So the Aymara pattern is not so exotic; experiments find small effects outside language too

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MENTAL HEALTH is a FRAGILE OBJECT

Her mental health is fragile.
Handle him with care.
He broke under questioning.
His mind snapped.
She is easily crushed.
The experience shattered him.
I'm going to pieces.
He cracked up.

MIND is a MACHINE

We're still trying to grind out the solution.
My mind just isn't operating today.
Boy, the wheels are turning now!
I'm a little rusty today.
We're running out of steam.
He broke down.

The source domain has to exist first: this metaphor is not very old

LIFE is a JOURNEY: The Mapping

JOURNEY		LIFE
traveller	→	person living a life
destinations	→	purposes
routes	→	means of achieving them
impediments	→	difficulties
guides	→	counsellors
distance	→	progress
landmarks	→	how you gauge progress
provisions	→	resources and talents

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Metonymy: A Stands for B

The White House announced ...	building → institution
She enjoys reading Shakespeare.	author → works
The kettle is boiling.	container → contents
All hands on deck.	part → whole person

A shift of reference within one domain, based on **contiguity**, not similarity: the structure is already there

Metonymy vs. Metaphor

	metonymy	metaphor
domains	within one	across two
basis	contiguity	similarity
does	refers	structures
example	*Brussels decided ...*	*He attacked my argument.*

Metonymy: A stands for B. Metaphor: A is understood in terms of B

Kinds of Metonymy

PART for WHOLE (synecdoche)	*Can you lend a hand?*
WHOLE for PART (synecdoche)	*Palacký won the soccer.*
CONTAINER for CONTENT	*The lunch menu had five dishes.*
MATERIAL for OBJECT	*I won gold.*
PRODUCER for PRODUCT	*I'll get an IBM.*
PLACE for INSTITUTION	*Downing Street has made no comment.*
INSTITUTION for PEOPLE	*Albert raised its prices.*
PLACE for EVENT	*Hiroshima changed our view of war.*
CONTROLLED for CONTROLLER	*A truck rear-ended me.*
OBJECT for USER	*They are a hired gun.*

Metonymy in Asian Languages

PLACE for INSTITUTION		
永田町	*Nagatachō*	Japanese politics
霞が関	*Kasumigaseki*	the central bureaucracy
中南海	*Zhōngnánhǎi*	the Chinese leadership
PART for WHOLE		
人口	*rénkǒu*	population (“person mouth”)
手が足りない	*te ga tarinai*	short-handed (“hands lack”)

What are the equivalents in the language you are working on?

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Anger Has a Physiology

body heat	*hot under the collar*, *a hothead*, *a heated argument*
internal pressure	*I almost burst a blood vessel*, *I exploded at them*
redness	*scarlet with rage*, *flushed with anger*
agitation	*shaking with anger*, *hopping mad*, *all worked up*
blurred perception	*blind with rage*, *seeing red*, *couldn't see straight*

Emotions have conceptual structure, visible in metaphor. In the cultural model of anger of Lakoff and Kövecses (1987), the effects grow with the anger, up to a limit beyond which we cannot function

The Body Is a Container

He was filled with anger.
She couldn't contain her joy.
She was brimming with rage.
Get the anger out of your system.

Combine it with ANGER is HEAT and you get the central metaphor: ANGER is a **HOT FLUID in a CONTAINER**

ANGER is a Hot Fluid in a Container

cool = calm	*Keep cool. Stay calm.*
heat	*You make my blood boil. Simmer down! She was seething.*
rising	*His anger welled up. Pretty soon I was in a towering rage.*
pressure	*He was bursting with anger. He kept it bottled up.*
explosion	*She blew up at me. She blew a fuse. He erupted.*
parts fly off	*I blew my top. She flipped her lid. He hit the ceiling.*

pissed off is only used for anger: hot liquid under pressure

The Container Has a Limit

- A closed container takes only so much heat: the anger scale has a **limit**
- The metaphor is motivated by our **physiology**
- Other metaphors exist too:

ANGER is FIRE
ANGER is INSANITY
ANGER is an OPPONENT
ANGER is a DANGEROUS ANIMAL

Lamaholot: ANGER is HOT SPICES

(1) one=k helo n-o'oN sili lia'
heart=1SG.POSS like 3SG-exist chilli ginger
"I am furious" (lit. "there are chilli and ginger in my heart") [slp]

Adonara-Lamaholot is spoken on eastern Flores, Solor and Lembata, in eastern Indonesia. From the PhD thesis of Elvis Albertus bin Toni (NTU 2018)

Mandarin: The Container Holds 气 *qì*

生气	*shēngqì*	get angry ("produce *qi*")
消气	*xiāoqì*	calm down ("dissipate *qi*")
气死我了	*qì sǐ wǒ le*	I'm furious ("*qi* killed me")

English	hot **fluid** under pressure
Mandarin	excess **qi**, to be released or dispersed

The container and the pressure are shared; the substance comes from traditional Chinese medicine

Japanese and Korean: Belly, Head and Fire

腹が立つ	*hara ga tatsu*	get angry (“the belly stands up”)
頭に来る	*atama ni kuru*	get angry (“it comes to the head”)
화가 나다	*hwa-ga nada*	get angry (“fire comes out”)
속이 타다	*sok-i tada*	fret (“the insides burn”)

Korean *hwa* is Sino-Korean 火 “fire”. The same broad picture (container, heat, something rising) with different body parts and substances. Where does anger live in your language?

Universal and Variable

universal	shared bodies: the pressurized container
variable	the substance: fluid, *qi*, chilli

Kövecses (2005). Two easy mistakes: calling a metaphor universal because English and one other language have it, or culturally specific because you haven't found it elsewhere yet

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PERSON is ANIMAL

He is a pig.	dirty, greedy
She is a fox.	cunning; or attractive
Don't be such a sheep.	unthinking follower

Built on the **cultural stereotype** of the animal, not its behaviour, so the same animal can map differently across cultures: a good test of universality

Animal Metaphors in East Asia

狐	*kitsune*	fox; a sly, deceptive person
狐狸精	*húlijīng*	fox spirit; a seductive woman
犬	*inu*	dog; a snitch, spy
청개구리	*cheong-gaeguri*	tree frog; a contrary person

English *dog* and Czech *pes* do not mean “informer”. Does your language have an animal for “informer”?

This Week's Task: PERSON is ANIMAL

- In pairs or triples, **before next week**: pick a language from the shared sheet (or add one)
- For each English metaphor: can your language say it?

it works	give the translation, mark **Y**
it doesn't	mark **N**
a different sense	add a row with a definition
other animal metaphors	add them, with both meanings

We compare in class. The data sheet is linked from this week's course page

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Conclusions

- Categories have **prototypes**; metaphor and metonymy extend them
- Metaphor structures **argument, time, emotion** and **people**
- East and Southeast Asia share the broad mappings, realized with different **bodies, substances** and **animals**

Idioms we learn; metaphors we work out on the fly (the line is fuzzy). Saeed (2015): Metaphor 11.4, Metonymy 11.5

Further Reading

- Ning Yu (1998) *The Contemporary Theory of Metaphor: A Perspective from Chinese*. John Benjamins: a book-length treatment of Chinese metaphor, including 气
- Andrew Goatly (2006) Humans, Animals, and Metaphors. *Society & Animals* 14:1, pp. 15–37
- Shelley Ching-yu Hsieh (2006) A corpus-based study on animal expressions in Mandarin Chinese and German. *Journal of Pragmatics* 38, pp. 2206–2222
- Kövecses (2005): the standard reference on universality and cultural variation

Glossary (English–Czech)

English	Čeština	English	Čeština
basic level category	základní úroveň kategorizace	orientational metaphor	orientační metafora
conceptual metaphor	konceptuální metafora	polysemy	polysémie
conventional	konvenční	prototype	prototyp
dead metaphor	mrtvá metafora	radial category	radiální kategorie
embodied	vtělený	source domain	zdrojová doména
idiom	idiom	spatial metaphor	prostorová metafora
linguistic relativity	jazykový relativismus	synecdoche	synekdocha
metaphor	metafora	systematic	systematický
metonymy	metonymie	target domain	cílová doména
ontological metaphor	ontologická metafora		

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John I. Saeed. 2015. *Semantics*. Wiley-Blackwell, fourth edition.